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Structure

“I resign!”

I was among some 150 youthful SNCC organizers packed into the social hall of Gammon Theological Seminary in Atlanta, Georgia, for the December 1965 staff meeting. We all gasped as Bob Moses, the highly respected director of the Mississippi Summer Project, announced his resignation. His last name was no longer Moses, his father’s name, he said. Now he was Bob Parris, his mother’s name. We were stunned. What just happened? What did it mean? What now?

Since the end of the Summer Project, SNCC had been struggling not only with heightened tensions over race, gender, and size but also with strategic direction after the defeat at the Democratic National Convention in Atlantic City. The small, intimate, consensus-governed, mostly Black, direct-democracy SNCC had ballooned in size, become more diverse (more white), and developed much more organizational complexity. At the center of it all was the Mississippi Summer Project, the project Bob had led since 1961.

SNCC was rich in committed, creative, and purpose-driven leadership—Jim Foreman, John Lewis, Ruby Doris Robinson, Stokely Carmichael, and others—but Bob had been a unique point of stability, bridging Black and white, inside and outside, novice and experienced. Without agreed-upon rules, practices, or processes—without clear structure—Bob’s move plunged SNCC into a painful loss of direction, endless meetings, acute internal divisions, increasing racial tension, and frustration.

My experience in the UFW, on the other hand, revealed how much we could achieve with clear, if far-from-perfect, decision-making, accountability, and learning—one reason I stayed for sixteen years. With a clear structure, one campaign after another could add up. The energy of change created the power of continuity.

But this too came to an end, at least in part due to structural failure. We had failed to construct intermediate levels of power, like a regional local union, between the hundreds of local ranch committees and an eight-person national board led by Cesar Chavez. Without this level of leadership,

accountability, and distributed power, the organization was ill equipped to survive the tragic political paranoia that in the mid-1970s gripped Chavez and sent the entire organization into a tailspin.¹

My experience at SNCC taught me the dangers of a radical diffusion of power. My experience with the UFW taught me the dangers of a radical concentration of power. It turns out that we cannot rely on even the most virtuous of individuals to stay on mission in the absence of virtuous institutions.

What Is Structure?

When we join others in making a commitment to where, when, and for how long we will meet, we create structure, from the Latin “to build.” By building structure, we can reduce future uncertainty and conserve creative energy by building a predictable space in which we can coordinate, collaborate, innovate, and organize the work we need to do to achieve shared goals.

Most of us do expect to honor our commitments (one reason we may be reluctant to make them), and we expect others to honor theirs. And because we are far from perfect, we also need to agree on how to hold ourselves and each other accountable. When we build structure, we invest it with the authority of legitimate rules, processes, and procedures with which we can govern ourselves. The greater the number of people trying to work together, the greater their need for shared, accessible, and transparent rules, processes, and procedures.

We create space by creating structure. The alternative is not liberty but chaos. But not all structures are created equal. Some structures can be used to constrain more than to enable. They resist change, tolerate stagnation, and court collapse. Other structures can be used to enable more than they constrain. Do they facilitate authoritative participation, collaboration, and dissent? Do they facilitate responsiveness to change, assure equitable accountability, and prevent concentrating too much power in too few hands? Because change is a constant, we can more usefully think of structure, like strategy, as more of a verb than a noun.

In this chapter we will focus primarily on how authority is structured. Interacting with the authority structure, however, are two other dimensions of structure: how resource flows are structured and how the work itself is structured (Figure 6.1). In addition, informal social networks interact with all three.

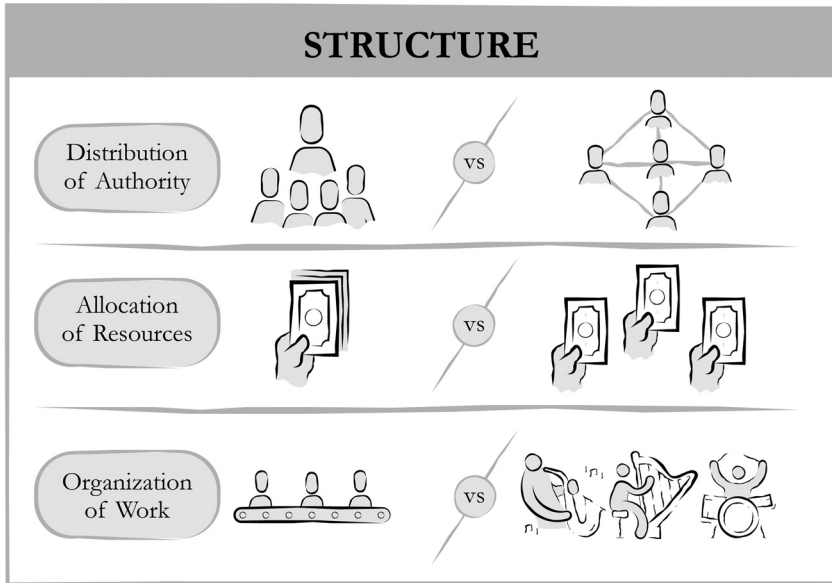


Figure 6.1 Structure. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

We considered the significance of resource flows in the prior chapter: do resources come from the inside or the outside, and are they principally money or people? When one is trying to understand how an organization works, the power dynamics may have more to do with how resource flows are structured than with anything else. For example, although authority may be equally distributed among members of a board, if one member represents a unit that contributes 40 percent of the budget, far more than any other, this will amplify the power of his or her voice, no matter the formal equality. In the UFW, one of the tensions was whether contracts could be won based on each worker's resource of his or her labor, often in the form of a strike, or on resources contributed by supporters in the form of purchasing power, usually a boycott, access to which was controlled by the central leadership of the union.

The way work itself is structured also matters. Is it designed more like an assembly line, supervised by a single foreman, in which each person does their prescribed, often repetitive task? Or is it designed more like a team, requiring interdependent collaboration? I saw this very clearly in Salinas Valley in the difference between an hourly compensated hoeing crew, each hewing to his or her row, with one supervisor. The lettuce harvest crews,

on the other hand, were paid by an amount per box, divided among a crew of twenty-five. The crew then decided how to distribute the pay among the “trios” of two cutters and one packer, a closer for every two trios, and a loader for every six or so. When it came to holding the power, the lettuce crews, far and away, had the most solidarity, coherence, and mutual support.

And finally, an informal structure with impact is that of the relationships among persons within the organization: did they go to the same prep school, did they come from the same town in Mexico, did they belong to the same neighborhood gang, do their kids go to the same school, or are they simply friends whose families hang out together? In fact, in the absence of clear formal authority structures, it will often devolve into opaque interpersonal relationships.

Structuring the practice of democracy is what this chapter is about.

Four Structural Tensions

In the months immediately following Trump’s election, Americans banded together in groups small and large to express their outrage with the administration’s policies. Seven years later, many of these groups have disbanded, not so much due to expected opposition but more likely overcome by structural challenges, organizational dysfunction, and insecure funding. Only rarely did they scaffold leadership development, commit to robust forms of self-government, establish deep membership financial support, or become effective voices in regional or national decision-making, including the choice of their own leadership. Although many conceived of themselves as national in purpose, too often they devolved into local groups, capable of making authoritative claims neither regionally nor nationally. Nor could they hold state or national entities with which they were associated accountable. Nor could their state or national entities hold locals accountable. Without structures for peer organizational learning, local groups missed opportunities to learn from each other’s failures and successes. The result minimized local, state, and national capacity for power building in the name of individual liberty, local autonomy, or resistance to bureaucracy. Some groups survived to become for-profit firms or nonprofit firms dependent on major donors. There are exceptions, mostly at the local level. Some owed their effectiveness to volunteers who belonged to a church, a union, a PTA, a soccer league, or another remnant of Tocqueville’s great free schools of democracy. Others

may have been trained in the 2008 Obama campaign. And still others, organized in the Alinsky mode, have built long-lasting community organizations, rooted mostly in local parishes, synagogues, and mosques, launched long before Trump and each of which tackles diverse “issues” that can contribute to growing the power of the organization.² They remain almost exclusively local, barred from political action and unable to engage power structured at the state or national levels. Few are governed by leadership accountable to a membership base that neither elects nor funds them, most dependent on donors, large and small.³ The truth is that claims we make to justice or policy have little clout without a vision of the organization or institution we are building to sustain growth of the power our constituency needs. Winning a single campaign—or even a series of them—is a good thing. But only rarely does winning a campaign shift the balance of power: wins are too easily reversed, promises not lived up to, and control reverts to the hands that held it before. Deep change requires organizing the sustained power to win it, keep it, and grow it. In the UFW, we knew we were building a union, so every individual campaign, won or lost, could contribute to that objective. Over the years many strikes had led to short-term wage increases but not to the sustained power needed to change the rules of the game. Organization enables people to transform individual interests into common interests, individual resources into collective power, and short-term wins into long-term power.

So a major challenge has been more focus on issues and campaigns than on power and organization. Although SNCC was a “band” of organizers engaged in numerous campaigns, the campaigns, in many cases, were about building powerful locally rooted organizations: the Mississippi Freedom Democratic Party, Lowndes County Freedom Organization, and others. In fact, SNCC could be quite critical of campaigns led by Dr. King, who would arrive in town, stir things up, and leave few remnants behind. In the UFW as well, I led many campaigns, but the project there too was to build an organization strong enough to sustain, grow, and expand the power of its constituency: a farmworkers’ union.

Democracy is a way to structure collective authority rooted in the equal worth of each person’s voice in concert with others. It is, in the words of Charles Taylor, an effort to govern ourselves rooted in commitment to equality, solidarity, and freedom.⁴

Given the reality of cultural, racial, ethnic, generational, economic, and religious conflict, pluralism in terms of identity, interests, and values democracy requires political structuring that affirms individual and minority

rights within governance by the many. This is particularly challenging in the United States, because the nonrepresentative and anti-majoritarian features of our Constitutional structure—the Senate, first-by-the-post elections, gerrymandered and noncompetitive districts—make it possible for a relatively homogeneous minority to dominate a far more heterogeneous majority.⁵ It isn't just a matter of crossing the aisle. As James Baldwin is said to have observed, "We can disagree and still love each other unless your disagreement is rooted in my oppression and denial of my humanity and right to exist."

For those committed to democracy, the development of an experiential, moral, or values-based narrative—or identity—within which these kinds of differences can be situated can be one way to address this challenge. Relationship building can also contribute. But neither shared narrative nor relationship building is sufficient in the absence of organizational structures that enable people to work together, make decisions, coordinate action, and hold themselves accountable.

The structural challenge is to design a way that legitimate decisions can be made in the name of the whole community, based on the equal authoritative value of each person's voice and enacted in ways that both respect each person's voice and can get things done.

For example, we may hear each person's voice when we decide to build a new school. We may deliberate with each other in a process in which each voice has equal value, after which we may decide by a majority vote. Who then is responsible for getting the school built? All of us? Let's say we commit to building the school with our own hands. What if some people are more able than others? Many of us lack the requisite skills, or we can't take off work. Most likely we would select—or already have selected—one person or a small team who accepts responsibility to make it happen. Do we continue to take votes on every step they take, or have we delegated to them the authority to do what must be done to get it done, including holding us accountable to the commitments we make, in return for which they accept responsibility for getting the school built, subject to the approach we had decided to take? Similarly, when we commit to a campaign, do we expect to vote on every strategic choice those who hold responsibility for leading the campaign must make?

We may all participate in robust debate about whether to take the hill, but we structure ourselves differently when it comes to actually taking the hill. This is one of the dilemmas of a commitment to self-governance: When does

authority flow from the bottom up, and when must it flow from the top down or, if you prefer, from the outside in or from the inside out?

When we create any structure, democratic or not, we must tackle four core dilemmas (Figure 6.2). How can we facilitate change and enable continuity? Whom do we include and whom do we exclude in what decisions and what actions? How do we sustain the diversity to facilitate inclusion, creativity, and accountability and simultaneously ensure the unity that enables focus, coordination, and collective action? How can parts participate in constructing a whole greater than a sum of the parts? And how can a whole facilitate development of strong parts? In this chapter we explore tensions inherent in the structuring of democratic collective action: change and continuity, inclusion and exclusion, unity and diversity, and parts and wholes.

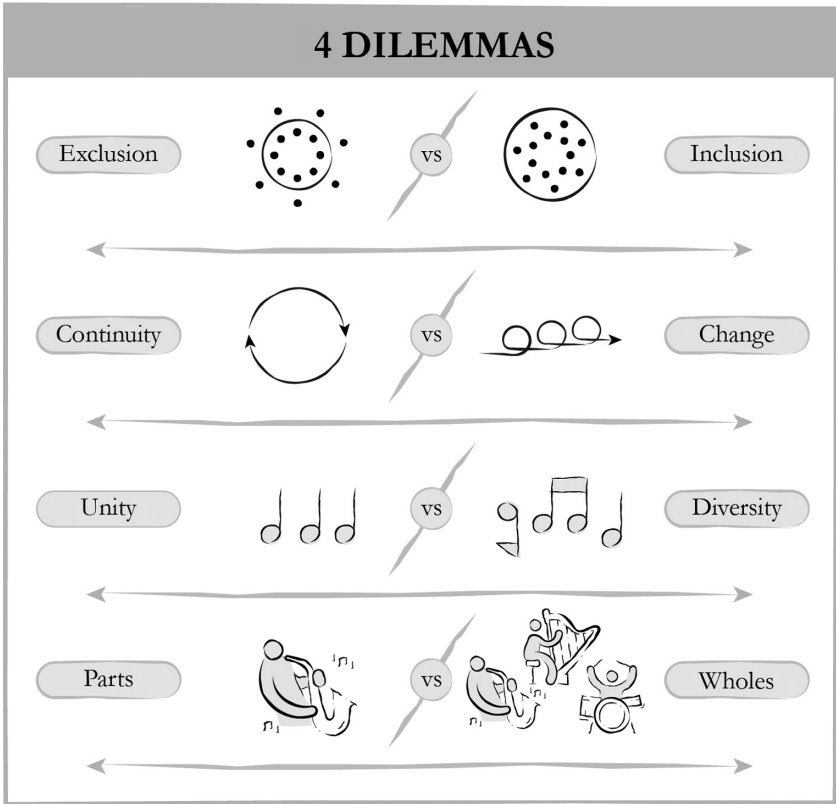


Figure 6.2 4 Dilemmas. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

Change and Continuity

Organizing is usually about change, but organization requires continuity. Organizing a campaign requires urgency, focus, capacity building, and adaptation. It moves from a status quo condition to a future and different condition. Organization requires predictability, stability, and coherence. It is about turning new conditions created by a campaign into the capacity for a sustained exercise of power. Sustained vitality, relevance, and effectiveness require adaptation driven by new voices, experiences, and learning. Continuity requires predictable ways to hear these voices, respond to these experiences, and engage in learning.

Continuity: Organization

For purposes of this book, I distinguish between organizations structured as firms and those structured as associations. Complex organizations can be distinguished by whether authority flows from the top down or from the bottom up. Businesses, nonprofit firms, and bureaucracies structure authority—as well as financial and other resources—to flow downward from an owner, set of owners, donors, or boards to top managers, middle managers, and workers. Complex organizations do not have members. They have customers or clients to whom they market goods or services, and they hire employees whose time and compliance they buy. Authority is based on ownership (property),⁶ with leaders exercising authority based on delegation by their superiors. Firms may be inclusive and even participatory, but they are not democratic. Although both forms of organization have politics, the coin of firm politics is authority itself, that is, palace or insider politics. The coin of associational politics is the support of membership. Organizing—empowering people—is about building associations.

Unions and civic and professional association's structure authority to flow upward from individual members who elect local leaders, regional leaders, and national leaders, each of whom is authorized to make decisions within their domain. Authority is based on membership (people). Elected leadership may work full time or part time and may recruit or hire full-time or part-time administrators who provide services and/or organizers who recruit, equip, and coordinate members to participate. Authority flows upward as to basic rules, choice of leadership, and broad policy. And even though authority usually flows downward or outward as to programs, projects, and campaigns, in the past, financial and membership resources flowed upward.

This changed in the last thirty to forty years, as professionals could use communication technologies to generate both money and members directly from a center that distributes these resources downward. What had been a bi-directional flow of authority and resources made leading an association far more challenging than managing a firm.⁷ The fact that resource flows are far less bi-directional has made sustaining the democratic character of many associations significantly more problematic as well. Yet it is associations, not firms, that have always been our “great free schools of democracy.”

Religious, political, and advocacy groups, as well as social movements more generally, structure themselves in both ways. The Roman Catholic Church, for example, structures authority to flow top down, like a firm, perhaps guided by the subsidiarity principle that decision-making be delegated down to the lowest level practical but is very active in motivating participation as well as significant resources from the bottom up. Many Protestant churches, Muslim mosques, and Jewish congregations, on the other hand, structure authority and resources to flow from the bottom up, like an association, guided by the federal principle of delegating authority upward. As a membership-based organization that derives its funds from members and elects its membership at the local, state, and national levels, the NRA operates as an association. Ironically, in most community organizations, no matter how hard the staff works to engage them, those they call their “base” do not elect leadership, hold staff accountable, pay for the organization, or govern themselves.

To the extent that a membership association aspires to make an impact (even a local impact), it often requires reaching beyond the local, and it will grow larger, become more geographically diffuse, acquire more assets, engage in tasks of greater complexity, try to preserve more lessons from its past, and try to extend its horizons further into the future. This is also known as “getting to scale” and requires and facilitates greater complexity in authority structures, routines of practice, and resource configurations. Operating this kind of organization requires commitment of more—and different—resources, energy, and leadership.

This phenomenon puts associations at risk of falling victim to what sociologist Robert Michels described as the “iron law of oligarchy”: the operations side can take over the policymaking side. As more resources are devoted to the organization itself, the goals of the organization may transform into sustaining the organization itself as a goal. This is especially problematic if, as it grows, the organization’s work grows more specialized and requires more

full-time elected or appointed staff. As such, the staff may compete for organizational resources, using its control over resources to insulate itself from membership accountability.⁸

Further, a kind of elective affinity may come into play to the extent that this organizational tension reflects conflicts in our own feelings about stability and change. On the one hand, our curiosity, sense of adventure, and desire to learn may draw us to innovate. On the other hand, our need for predictability, proficiency, and stability may cause us to fear innovation. Although most of us experience both kinds of pull, some of us are drawn more to the innovative, evangelical, and experimental, while others are attracted to the stable, predictable, and proficient. The fact that people with different dispositions converge in different parts of an organization creates the possibility of either constructive synergy or organizational fragmentation.⁹

This challenge can become acute in membership associations. An association that successfully grows its membership creates the constituency most inclined to resist investing organizational resources in further growth. The issue becomes particularly acute in that control over organizational resources falls naturally into the hands of those stabilizing the organization to a greater degree than those growing it—into the hands of bishops, in other words, rather than missionaries. It is therefore essential to build in strong accountability mechanisms at both the individual and the organizational levels from the beginning.

Change: Campaigns

We build organizations to enable continuity, but we launch campaigns to create change. If we structure an organization to remain responsive to its constituency, support ongoing renewal, invite dissent, and sustain capacity for unified action, we structure campaigns to deploy people for a limited period by focusing on achieving a particular outcome. Organizing requires both forms of structure.

Our word “campaign” comes from the French *campagne*, the word for field, and that came to describe an army’s process of taking the field. Campaigns are not designed to last. They are designed to win. They are a very focused, intensive, deadline-driven stream of activity, launched on a particular day to achieve a particular goal at a particular time by winning a particular battle. The winner then gets either to impose welcome change or to have resisted unwelcome change.

A campaign is structured strategically as an unfolding narrative or story. It begins with a foundation period (prologue), starts crisply with a kickoff (curtain goes up), builds slowly to successive peaks (act 1, act 2), culminates in a final peak determining the outcome (denouement), and is resolved as we celebrate the outcome (epilogue). Our efforts generate momentum not mysteriously, but as a snowball. As we accomplish each objective, we generate new resources that can be applied to achieve the subsequent greater objective. Our motivation grows as each small success persuades us that the subsequent success is achievable—and our commitment grows.

Campaign timing is structured in clear phases, with a peak climaxing each phase—a specific day when your whole campaign will deploy its full current capacity to cross a qualitative threshold, the result of which will be a whole new level of capacity. In organizing, our first major peak may be when we focus most of our effort on turning people out from across the region to kick off the campaign. Happily, many actually show up. The region is divided into five districts, so we can pull together the people who came from each district. We can then support them in organizing their own team in each district, each of which can organize their own kickoff. And so forth.

After each peak, your staff, volunteers, and members need time to rest, learn, retrain, and plan for the next phase. Often organizations say, “We don’t have time for that!” This is a mistake. Campaigns that don’t take time to reflect, adjust, and retrain end up burning through their human resources—treating them more like “resources” than like “humans” and becoming more and more reactionary over time.

When it comes to authority, most campaigns are strategically led from a center. Whether centered on a neighborhood, city, state, national, or global campaign, strategic focus matters. Yet good strategy requires an overview of the whole (from the mountaintop) with a nuanced view of the local (down in the valley). Wise campaigns combine leadership from a center not only with information gathered locally but with local strategic leadership as well. The effectiveness of the campaign on the ground may depend on local leadership with the responsibility—and authority—to organize their own turf, adapting to local nuance, constraint, and opportunity. This tension is more easily managed if a campaign is local, but a very similar tension can play out between neighborhood leadership and that of a city as a whole. The key is to structure a campaign in a way that connects the information needed, the skills required, and the authority to decide what is right in the right locations.

We must also distinguish between the far more common mobilizing campaigns than organizing campaigns. A mobilizing campaign usually concentrates authority at the center, based on whatever form of information is available to the center (often digitally mediated, like polling or modeling) and what control is accessible. At times, control goes all the way down to the script a local volunteer can use to speak to a particular voter, whether digitally or in person (message control). The volunteer is a messenger delivering a prescribed message and not an organizer, even if the campaign calls the messenger an organizer.

An organizing campaign requires that authority be much more widely distributed so that decisions can be made about how to proceed based on information only locally accessible. The 2008 Obama campaign structured itself at state, regional, local, and even polling-place levels because the campaign leadership understood that developing trained, committed, and responsible local leadership could maximize voter turnout. Authority then was nested all the way up—at the precinct, region, district, city, state, and national levels—with coaching, training, accountability, and support available at every level. Consequently, the campaign invested in the development of more civic capital than anything before or since.

So where does the democracy come in? Does everyone vote on campaign strategy? If so, who is included in “everyone”? Who is responsible for making the strategy work? Does everyone decide their own local strategy even if it is a regional, state, or national campaign?

One way to look at this is to ask how widely distributed authority is throughout the campaign structure. For example, one could argue that a team structure is more “democratic” than a single leader structure in the way it creates interdependence and distributes responsibility—and the authority to go with it.

Another way to look at it is to ask, Who decided to do the campaign in the first place? Was it an organization? Was it a democratic association in which authority is rooted in the participants, or a democratic association in which authority is rooted in the organizers? Was it an NGO—a type of firm—in which authority is rooted in a self-selected board? Did the decision not come from an organization at all, but rather from a wealthy funder or candidate?

In other words, the place to look for democracy may not be in the campaign itself, but rather in the structure of the organization that decided to launch the campaign and that may benefit from it. And this brings us back to the tensions associated with inclusion and exclusion.

Inclusion and Exclusion

Whose voices are heard? Whose voices count? Anyone who shows up at a meeting? The founders and their friends? People who commit to obligations in return for voice and the rights and benefits that come with it: citizens, members, dues payers? People appointed by a board. People chosen to speak on behalf of a whole. Chosen or elected? By whom?

In democratic associations, the first question is, who is a member? Who gets the right to authoritative voice in the commons in return for commitments the commons require? Individuals acquire such rights as choosing leadership, deciding on policy, and so on, in return for accepting such obligations as paying dues, honoring norms, respecting legitimate decisions, and attending meetings. In this way, individual interests can be transformed into common interests and individual resources into collective power.

Economist Albert Hirschman described this arrangement as the promise of voice in return for loyalty.¹⁰ No collective can survive based on rights alone: show up whenever, participate when you like, respect decisions if it suits. In the absence of voice, Hirschman argues, exit is the only option if things don't go your way. Exit is how markets work. The difference between the two highlights how political decisions about common interests differ from the way markets transform individual preferences into narrowly efficient, if not just or wise, outcomes. Consumers enter a marketplace at will, exercise their preferences, and exit. But these are mechanisms of transaction, not of commitment, combination, and politics. Obligations give us an interest in making the community work, even when it is difficult and when we disagree with it. Constituents enter into a relationship with each other, accept responsibility for the whole, and get access to the power that grows with it.

Who is in and who is out? And who decides who is in and who is out? Every act of inclusion also excludes: at the moment we define our bounded in, our "us," we also define a bounded out, our "not-us." On the one hand, boundaries may limit our capacity for inclusion. On the other hand, a community—or, for that matter, a marriage, a family, or any other kind of group—without boundaries is not a community. The question, then, is not whether we bound an organization, but rather how we bound it that gives it an identity shared by those who participate in it.

We need bounding to create trust among the members, as organizational behavior scholars Kenwyn K. Smith and David N. Berg articulate:

For a group to develop the critical internal relationships so that it can become an entity worthy of being trusted, it needs to have the trust of its members and the assurance they will stand by the group through the bad times and the good. The paradox of trust can be represented by the conundrum of a cycle that depends on itself to get started: for trust to develop in a group, members must trust the group and the group must trust its members, for it is only through trusting that trust is built.¹¹

Clear boundaries as a key component of organizational structure empower members to understand and embrace the responsibilities that come with membership. Amorphous structures create situations in which members experience confusion, and sometimes resentment, about what they're being asked to do. When I, as a member, confuse the commitments that I have chosen with bureaucratic obligations that are imposed upon me by someone else, I've made a serious mistake. I have confused the responsibilities of membership in a multitiered organization that delegates authority upward with the burdens of a top-down organization that delegates control downward. The less clarity and transparency an organization has about its structure, the more likely members are to experience the kind of confusion that creates organizational dysfunction.

In democratic organizations, each of us—or our representatives—can participate in and decide on the structure to which we will commit: the rules, processes, and procedures that enable us to work together, including boundaries for participation and decision-making.

Unity and Diversity

Diversity is an asset when it comes to strategizing, learning, inclusion, and collaboration; it helps us avoid groupthink. But once we have decided on a course of action, we need unity in carrying it out. Deep-rootedness in diverse local communities can be a source of real strength, but coordination in the pursuit of common regional or national goals can be a source of real power. Diversity of experience, skill, and perspective can be a vital resource when we form a team, but unity of shared purpose is required for that team to become functional.

Without knowing who is in a group, the cycle of trust—which is difficult to begin, even with organizational boundaries in place—is even more difficult

to set in motion. Bounding an organization also entails setting norms for the organization. While norms will develop naturally whether we set them explicitly or not, we are better off being explicit. As social psychologist Richard Hackman explains, we must set norms explicitly to counter human tendencies that lead to unproductive organizational work:

A first ordinary tendency is our disposition to react to whatever captures our attention and demands a response, rather than to actively scan our environment for less obvious problems and opportunities that may call for nonstandard actions. . . .

A second human tendency . . . is our understandable impulse to have harmonious interactions with others, to be approved rather than rejected by our teammates, and generally to keep anxieties as low as possible.

Third, as a group sets explicit norms to approach its work proactively and agrees on “the outer-limit boundaries of what behaviors are acceptable,” it can effectively counter these tendencies.¹²

Unity is the source of a membership association’s power because it is through combination that associations acquire the resources they can deploy to create the power they need. At the same time, diversity is often the most critical source of an association’s creativity, accountability, and ability to learn. As social psychologists have learned, the more homogeneous a group, the better it can be at taking the hill, but the more diverse a group, the better the decisions it will make about whether to take the hill in the first place.¹³

Dissent, in other words, can be associated with better decisions, but poorer performance. Unanimity can be associated with better performance, but poorer decisions. Too much unity (such as groupthink) can stifle an organization by destroying its responsiveness to its constituency and its capacity for renewal. If an association fragments into factions, each of which views its interests as the interests of the whole, it loses the capacity to discern the common interests that make combination possible, let alone the capacity to translate those interests into the effective mobilization and deployment of resources.

Dissent is critical for decision-making processes, but dissent on its own can be divisive and lead to scapegoating within an organization. A group needs to be able to receive negative feedback about its processes to learn and grow, but the message may feel like an assault on the group’s norms. The bind is that the group may elect not to listen to the very things it needs to

hear. Instead, it may choose to reject the carrier of the message so that it does not have to deal with the message, treating the concerns as “belonging” to the person expressing them rather than seeing this as an integral part of the group itself.

Parts and Wholes

Groups that find success typically desire growth. The campaign worked: Let's do another one! The neighborhood chapter made city hall listen: Let's build citywide! While scaling up offers the thrilling possibility of making change at scale, growth creates another set of tensions about the relationship between parts and whole that leaders engaged in democratic practices must ultimately confront.

Although exclusively local groups may operate as single entities, many associations or movements find they must coordinate their efforts across localities or at regional, national, or international levels. Until the 1960s, this challenge was often addressed through the formation of three-tiered, federated structures that linked local, state, national, and, in some cases, transnational efforts.¹⁴ This form persists in unions, some faith communities, and membership organizations like the Sierra Club. But many individuals and movements have, especially in recent years, come to view this structure as bureaucratic, controlling, and stifling.

The challenge is how to harmonize local units with regional and national strategy and regional and national strategy with local units to enable the trans-local coordination, learning, and mutual support needed to win. Although many view decentralized local organizations as democratic and responsive (good), and the trans-local and centralized as oligarchic and unresponsive (bad), local groups, too, can become oligarchic and unresponsive, and national groups, democratic and responsive.

Political scientist E. E. Schattschneider, writing about political conflict, argues that widening participation by linking groups across localities is a way to amass the power one needs to accomplish organizational goals (by pooling resources, creating a broader strategic venue, etc.). Additionally, geographical growth facilitates accountability—both to one's constituency and to the broader goals on behalf of which one organized in the first place. Schattschneider claims that elites try to localize conflict, while insurgents try to broaden the arena of conflict—they can access more allies, more diverse

resources, and more observers who can be mobilized for support. Trans-local organizations can moreover create venues within which local elites can be held more accountable. We seem to forget this reality with a focus on the virtues of local direct democracy over those of representative democracy.¹⁵

This argument builds on that of James Madison in *Federalist* Paper No. 10, where he argued that large democracy is preferable to small democracy because it is harder for a single faction to take control, turning the common interest into factional interest. Traditionally, corruption in the United States was far more common at the local and state levels than at the national level (although the Trump administration did its best to catch up).¹⁶ Organizationally, the greater the degree of local autonomy, the more vulnerable the organization is to oligarchy, not at the top but at the bottom. As such, it contributes to the fragmentation of organizational resources as each local group becomes a Madisonian faction, seeing its own interest as the interest of the whole. The whole can then become reduced to the lowest common denominator, less than the sum of the parts, rather than more.

This phenomenon grows out of the ways that associational members form their interests—their preferences. A carpenter working in commercial construction in San Francisco, with only a local organizational affiliation, may understand her interest entirely as a local carpenter. But if she also belongs to an organization that links all the San Francisco building trades, she may learn to see her interest more as a building tradesperson, not only a carpenter. If that unit, in turn, links people who work in the building trades with other working people in the area, it may turn out that she also has shared interests with other working people—such as transportation costs, access to health benefits, and so forth. This realization makes broader mobilization possible. And if this new grouping is also affiliated with a political party or other political grouping that links working people with others in a similar economic situation but who earn their incomes differently, common interests may emerge in public schools, parks, and other public facilities. Associations with which we affiliate not only represent our interests; they may shape our understanding of those interests as well. And the more interdependent we understand ourselves to be, the more broadly we can construe our interests to be as well.

Meeting this challenge is one version of the challenge that faces all democratic organizations: designing ways in which legitimate decisions can be made rooted in the equal value of each person's voice and enacted in ways that can get the job done. The goal is to create a structure that can assure authoritative participation, accountability, and effectiveness.

Unless our decision-making process is coupled with our getting-things-done process, and both are accountable to the membership, nothing may happen. For this to work, local groups, like individuals at local levels, must have a legitimate voice in decisions made at regional or national levels. At the same time, each person's responsibility of loyalty must be clear when it comes to acting on those decisions. Unfortunately, a common default position seems to offer each local group the autonomy to do what it will do, even though this will cripple trans-local strategy, learning, and development. Usually, though, once these local groups are launched, the larger organization loses interest in facilitating training, coaching, and other aspects of sustained development. Or the local groups respond to resist national bodies they experience as trying to impose illegitimate regional or national programs on the local group. The former is a formula for frustration, diffusion of effort, and failure; the latter, for ongoing conflict, resistance, and resentment.

The problem of parts and wholes is an organizational version of the strategic dilemma discussed in chapter 4: effective strategizing can occur only when the overview of the context from the top of the mountain is combined with the intimate view of context in the valley. One is not right, nor the other wrong. They are two perspectives that, when linked, transform the power of both on their own. Local groups that insist they can see the whole truth of the situation, or national groups that insist they can see the whole truth of the situation, are both missing the true picture. In concert with others, local leadership can compare practices, coordinate work on common challenges, and place their local experience within a broader statewide or national frame of reference.

Examples of the relationship among local control, accountability, and a broader mission can be found the labor movement. Unions structure themselves in a variety of ways, one metric of which is their degree of local, often craft-based, decentralization and regional, often industry-based, centralization. Examples of highly decentralized unions include the building trades, craft unions, and others that traditionally operated in local labor markets in which they could assert control by organizing highly skilled workers. These unions typically had very large locals, operated autonomously, and paid a very small per capita to their national organizations, which were typically governed by a national board dominated by the leaders of the large local unions.

In contrast, the industrial unions that organized employees of companies operating across multiple localities such as autos, rubber, or steel tended to

be more centralized. These unions could often only assert control in local labor markets by leveraging the influence they had in places where they enjoyed political support to organize other places where they did not. In the auto industry, for example, the UAW was able to use the leverage it held in Michigan, where it had conducted effective sit-down strikes without interference from a friendly governor, to organize other states where the politics or labor market conditions were far less friendly. These unions typically had locals of diverse sizes, organized into districts or regions or departments within which they had to collaborate to arrive at common positions, paid large per capita dues to their national organizations, and were governed by a board dominated by leaders elected on a regional or national basis. As a side note, the more radical socialist unionists also favored this form of centralized industrial organization to develop greater working-class consciousness and solidarity.

Which form is more oligarchic? Which is more corrupt? Which is more adaptive? Which is most democratic? What is the role of leadership and organizing with respect to these structures.

Both forms are vulnerable to oligarchic take over in the absence of robust mechanisms of internal accountability, and internal organizing. Incumbents tend to use the resources to which they, as incumbents, have access to do what they need to do to remain incumbents. As the Mexican saying goes, “entre menos burros, mas elotes”—the fewer the donkeys the more the corn. Michels famously identified this challenge as the “iron law of oligarchy”—full time officials, elected or not, sooner or later put their own interests, for the “good” of the organization itself, ahead of those of their members.¹⁷ Lipset further clarified the structural dimension of this problem as not simply a matter of “bad people.”¹⁸ Margaret Levy also identified conditions under which members are unlikely to challenge incumbents, whether corrupt or radical: having built enough bargaining power to deliver for them.¹⁹ Even though accountability mechanisms may exist, members may not want to take advantage of them.

In reality it takes **both** good leadership and organizing to put the accountability mechanisms to work . . . not so different from what it takes to make any democracy work. Structure may well be necessary but is insufficient for making a democracy work.

Although there have been notable oligarchic abuses in national unions, especially if members and weaker or strategically dependent locals rely on national economic, political, and strategic resources to function. For example,

the Teamsters in the Jimmy Hoffa era or the United Mine Workers in the Tony Boyle era.²⁰

Local large autonomous local unions are perhaps more vulnerable to oligarchic power grabs because it is all local: the work, the people, the bosses, the courts, the media, the golf courses, etc. Corruption of large locals became endemic, for example, in UNITE HERE, the hotel, restaurant, and culinary workers union, including locals “mobbed up” by the Mafia. Only an aggressive disciplined, strategic, and sustained internal organizing campaign, led by the national union could begin to take them back in the 1970s and 1980s.²¹ National unions not controlled by large locals can, at the very least offer support, intervention, and reform, along the lines of SEIU’s efforts in the 1980s and the 1990s.²²

National unions and local unions can run as effective democratic organizations. But without the leadership and organizing to use the accountability structures it won’t happen. Both can become oligarchic in the absence of such leadership, not to mention the structural tools with which to work.

Some of the most effective democratic unions are hybrids. These organizations figured out how to integrate the centralizing features that can afford more bargaining strength, educational resources, and political influence—and the “distributed” features of local and regional engagement and representation.

The United Auto Workers (UAW) can be a case in point. Since the 1940s the UAW, in the tradition of Walter Reuther, was a progressive, honest, and powerful hybrid union—at the local, regional, and national level.²³ The collapse of automobile manufacturing the more recent years of recovery only increased the gap between management profit and workers’ earnings and benefits tied to concessions made in the 1980s. So in 2020 autoworker Shawn Fain began to organize Unite All Workers for Democracy, an internal union reform caucus organization that seized an opportunity created by US Labor Department anti-corruptions. They won a structural change in how national officers are chosen. Instead of election by convention delegates it would be vote of the entire membership. They the organized the vote needed to win, organized support for long overdue contract improvements, which turned into support for a remarkable strike, and they won.²⁴

So here’s the point. They’re interdependent. Democratic structural features can make it possible. Leadership organizing can make it happen.²⁵ They can also make for a more powerful union.²⁶ And so, it is for making democracy work.

In sum, it's not all about "centralized" structure or "local" structure, but their integration that can offer the best means of integrating parts and whole, give insurgents room to maneuver, create broader strategic venues, create opportunity for broader understanding of common interest, and minimize oligarchic control. But all this only makes it more or less possible. It takes leadership and organizing to put it all together and make it happen.

Three Ways to Manage Tensions

Tensions are inevitable, even necessary, in democratic organizing, but they need not derail a movement. We can devise diverse strategies to manage the tensions—if we acknowledge them—that come with balancing continuity and change, inclusion and exclusion, and unity and diversity. Among these are distributing responsibility, facilitating collaboration, and preserving dissent (Figure 6.3).

Distribute Responsibility

An organization committed to leadership development and wide participation is better equipped to engage with change on an ongoing basis than an

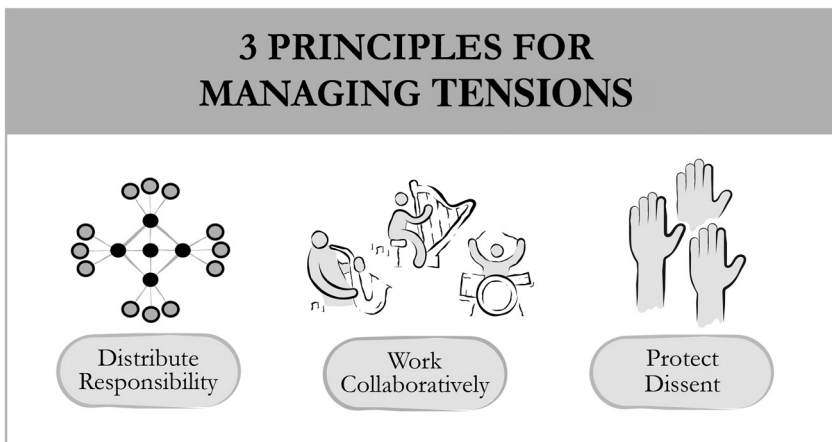


Figure 6.3 3 Principles for Managing Tensions. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

organization that walls its leadership off in a tight circle of control. Sustained commitment to identifying, recruiting, and developing new leaders, and to finding new ways to engage one's members more broadly, requires organizational leadership to respond to new currents, new ideas, and new challenges. Wide participation can also ensure ongoing responsiveness to the need for change, albeit within a framework with substantial continuity.

Similarly, openness to bringing in new people and broadening participation confronts leaders with the challenge of how to engage different kinds of people, people with different backgrounds. At the same time, openness creates venues within which members can express their concerns, be heard, and see evidence of organizational responsiveness. The more extensively responsibility is shared among the leadership and membership of an association, the more the parts come to understand—and play a part in—the whole, and the more the whole must understand about the interests and resources of the parts.

This is all very good, but what are the consequences of taking this approach for organizational performance in general? In membership associations, the more widely we share responsibility for organizational results, the greater interest the members acquire in the common effort and the more resources they will commit to its success. It may be more efficient to get five people to spend the whole day collecting signatures in a city, but it may be more effective to get ten teams of five to spend one hour each getting signatures in their own neighborhoods. Similarly, scholars of work organization have shown that distributing responsibility, or “vertically loading” jobs, can increase motivation and—by extension—productivity.²⁷

Second, distributing responsibility not only empowers an association by engaging the resources of more people. It also empowers more people within the organization because they hold the resources needed to do the work. The more members share the responsibility for doing the work, the more getting the work done depends on their cooperation. And the more cooperation it requires, the more resources that can make accountability real are placed in more hands. If only five people can do all the work, theirs are the only resources needed to get the job done, which means they may be the only ones with the power to exercise real accountability.

When an organization's work depends not on resources generated by the efforts of many people but on resources generated by a single fundraiser, who holds power within the organization? Have you ever been in a meeting where you start hearing about what the funders will support and won't support,

and why we need to do this or that so we can get the money—all, of course, interpreted by the person responsible for raising the money? No matter how democratic the formal structure of an organization, if one person's resources make the whole thing possible, that person will have the say. This is why effective democratic leadership rests on a solid practice of delegation—a practice that we focus on in our discussion of leadership.

Action entails cost but can also promise recognition. The more widely shared the cost—or sacrifice—the more people have a stake in the outcome. If one or two people do all the sacrificing, they quickly burn out, while everyone else blames them for whatever goes wrong. Similarly, when many people have an opportunity to contribute, they can also claim a share in success. It is their victory, not someone else's. This, in turn, creates motivation and a sense of entitlement that facilitates accountability. The wider the opportunity to act is, the wider the participation, the responsibility, and the capacity to hold leadership accountable will be.

It might not be surprising that we may resist distributing responsibility or widening participation to the extent that it threatens our control.

Facilitate Collaboration

Establishing collaborative work practices within an organization—for instance, teams, group deliberation, evaluation, peer learning, and so on—can help address the challenges of balancing change and continuity. This practice overcomes a critical barrier to ongoing adaptive change in the form of an isolated leadership that resists open evaluation.

Similarly, collaborative work practices help us manage the tension of unity and diversity. Leading a unified organization requires more than defensive maneuvers to avoid divisive factions. When done proactively, work can be designed to require greater interdependence, thus requiring more collaboration. One of the dangers of professionalizing an organization is that we may minimize interdependence. Instead of relying on a team of volunteers (and their inefficiencies), we hire someone to do their job. But something is lost with this choice. Whom does this empower within the organization? Whom does it disempower?

Effective collaboration depends on skilled leadership, a chief art of which is learning to blend the unique capacities—and deficits—of different people. This, of course, goes to the tensions around diversity and unity. Work

assignments are the result of a negotiation between the actual persons—their personalities, their experience, their talents, and their difficulties—and the roles they are needed to play. If everyone were the same age, race, and gender and had the same skills, life experience, and so forth, their “power with” would remain limited because of so little opportunity for productive interdependence. We can’t lift a table if we all lift the same corner at the same time. But if we each lift our own corner, we can. The trick is to match the right people with the right corners.

Effective collaboration also requires continuity. Richard Hackman offers this anecdote:

NTSB [National Transportation Safety Board] staff combed the agency’s database to identify the circumstances under which aircraft cockpit crews are most likely to get into trouble. They found that 73 percent of the incidents in the NTSB database occurred on the crew’s first day of flying together, and 44 percent of those took place on a cruise very first flight.

Hackman explains why flights get safer when flight crews work in familiar teams: “They learn who is especially knowledgeable or skilled about which aspects of the work and thereby build the team’s capability to actually *use* what members know and know how to do.”²⁸

Productive collaboration, then, is the result of harmony, not homogeneity. This is what it means to construct community based on difference. The idea is to create a star team, not to be a star player. A coach begins with the common interest a team has in winning. But it only becomes a winning team if the coach learns how to combine the unique strengths and weaknesses of each player. The team then has an interest in remaining a team.

Dissent Is Not Disloyalty

The capacity of an organization to respond to its constituency, their needs, and the world of change in which we are living requires accountability. Democracy grows out of a claim that leaders may lead in the public interest not because they are virtuous, but because the public has the power to hold them accountable. Accountability (as in electoral competition) is also a mechanism that requires democratic leaders to respond to new

circumstances, new constituencies, new challenges. For democratic organizations, responsiveness and renewal are thus directly linked with the legitimacy of dissent. Accountability only works when linked to the open debate of different points of view.

A loyal opposition not only holds leaders accountable but can become an agent of change by giving voice to alternatives that can stimulate an adaptive response. For this to work, however, requires a rich diversity of perspectives. This requires learning how to manage difference—neither denying it nor accepting it as absolute. The legitimacy of dissent requires agreed-upon ways we can continue collaborating, even when we disagree. This requires decision rules—rules that allow us to make decisions, move forward, and get work done, even if everyone doesn't agree. Formal procedures for debate, discussion, voting and evaluation can help by depersonalizing disagreements. *Robert's Rules of Order* may still have its uses.

Leaders can nurture a culture that values difference by affirming the single voice that the rest of the group tries to drown out, rather than joining the chorus. Learning to deliberate in ways that affirm our commonalities while protecting dissent can transform our diversity into an asset, which can aid us in realizing and acting upon our common interests. It is equally important to learn to celebrate in ways that affirm both the distinctiveness of our identities and the communality of our organizational undertaking.

Dissent can undoubtedly be uncomfortable. Dissent, however, is a fundamental source of learning, accountability, and the capacity of democratic associations to respond to change.

Meetings, Actions, Celebrations

When it comes to practice, the complex tensions just described are evident in the only three kinds of activities that organizations actually do: meet, act, and celebrate (Figure 6.4). *Meetings* are where much of the shared head work gets done in the form of deliberation, decision-making, learning, information sharing, and evaluation. They can also be excessive, especially when used to avoid challenging action. *Action* is the hands work: providing the service, organizing the march, recruiting new members, and researching critical information. *Celebration* is the heart work: sustaining commitment, honoring values, recognizing contributions, and affirming relationships.

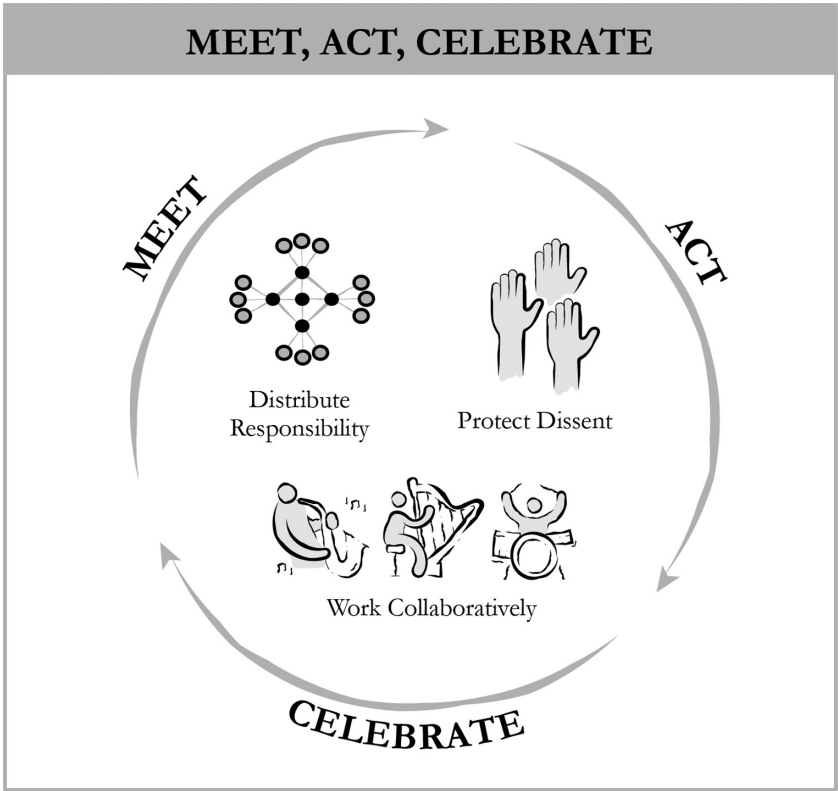


Figure 6.4 Meet, Act, Celebrate. *Source:* Steve Downer of the Difference

Ask yourselves to what extent distributed responsibility, facilitated collaboration, and respect for dissent are evident in your meetings, your actions, and your celebrations.

Meeting

While many meetings can take place between two individuals or small groups (indeed, some must), an association only really comes to life as a group of people assembled in a room (or on Zoom) deliberating about what they are doing together, sharing what they have been learning together, and engaging with the challenges they are facing.

How does distributing responsibility work in a meeting? How much effort is made to turn people out? Who participates in the planning team for the meeting? Who speaks in the meeting and what do they have to report on?

How about working collaboratively? What is the role of committees? How are committee reports handled? Is any collaborative work done in the meeting, like brainstorming? In large meetings, are groups from different locations identified by signs, symbols, or colors? And how is all the new information coming from participants integrated?

What norms have been established to establish that dissent is not disloyalty? Is there a role for a devil's advocate? How is debate structured? Are there rules of respect in place?

Acting

The second thing organizations do is act—conduct programs, run campaigns, provide services, and so on.

How does distributing responsibility work in acting? How widely has the responsibility for mobilizing participants been spread? Has responsibility for turnout been pushed all the way down, or only for sharing information? Are there teams? Team captains?

How about working collaboratively? How was the action planned? Who participated? Are there regular evaluations? Who participates? Are participants identified by their local group, their role in the organization, a symbol or logo?

What norms have been established to establish that dissent is not disloyalty? What procedures exist for people with complaints to have them heard? Does the leadership look for opportunities to act on suggestions voiced as dissent?

Celebrating

Finally, organizations celebrate their narrative, their successes, their setbacks, and their milestones.

How does pushing responsibility down and broadening participation work in celebrations? Is it a catered meal or a potluck? Are professional

entertainers hired or are members called upon to contribute? Who does the decorations? Who cleans up?

How does working collaboratively come into play? The whole way a celebration is planned, the way committees do their work, and how the event itself is conducted can be an opportunity for widespread collaboration, or you can just hire a professional event manager, if you have the money. But how about a talent show? And singing? Who will lead it? Will you open and close with a prayer, a poem, a reflection?

How does understanding that dissent is not disloyalty help celebrations? Think creatively about how to honor different points of view, different perspectives, and different angles on what is being celebrated.

Conclusion

Successful organizing—and practicing democracy as such—requires structuring. As Jo Freeman reminded us, whenever people get together with any interest in the future, they will structure themselves intentionally or not, consciously or not, and transparently or not.²⁹ The real question is not whether to structure but how to structure and how to embrace structure as a critical element of the organizing craft.

Structuring is not easy, any more than writing a constitution is. We create structure by committing to the ground rules by which we will govern ourselves. The ground rules really matter, in that they determine how we decide, how we hold ourselves responsible, how we resolve conflict, and how we facilitate change. In addition to ground rules, structure requires an agreed-upon shared purpose and clear roles.

In a recent version of my organizing class, we focused on how the structuring of leadership teams interacted with the development of plausible strategy. Of twenty-seven teams, only four failed to develop plausible strategy. Each of those teams had notably failed to create a viable structure. Not every well-structured team came up with great strategy, but they learned. The dysfunctional teams got nowhere.

In sum, building powerful civic associations poses important challenges that only come fully into play as we begin to succeed. The responsiveness, relevance, and continued vitality of our associations depend in great part

on how we learn to manage the dilemmas of change and continuity, inclusion and exclusion, unity and diversity, and parts and wholes. We have suggested three practices that can help: distributing responsibility, working collaboratively, and recognizing that dissent is not disloyalty. Keep us posted.